

CARRIER AND MARITIME STRIKE AIRCRAFT

Initially, the planes borne on aircraft carriers were no different to those that operated from terrestrial fields, but, by the mid-1920s, deliveries of aircraft modified for shipboard performance had begun. From that point on, the designs of carrier- and land-based aircraft began to diverge, although the latter were still useable on ships. As well as fighters, whose primary role was to defend the mother ship and other ships in the fleet, long-range reconnaissance aircraft and specialist attack aircraft armed with torpedoes or bombs were also commissioned. The latter were dominated by dive bombers during this period.



Narrow-track landing gear made take-off and landing difficult

▲ GRUMMAN F4F WILDCAT

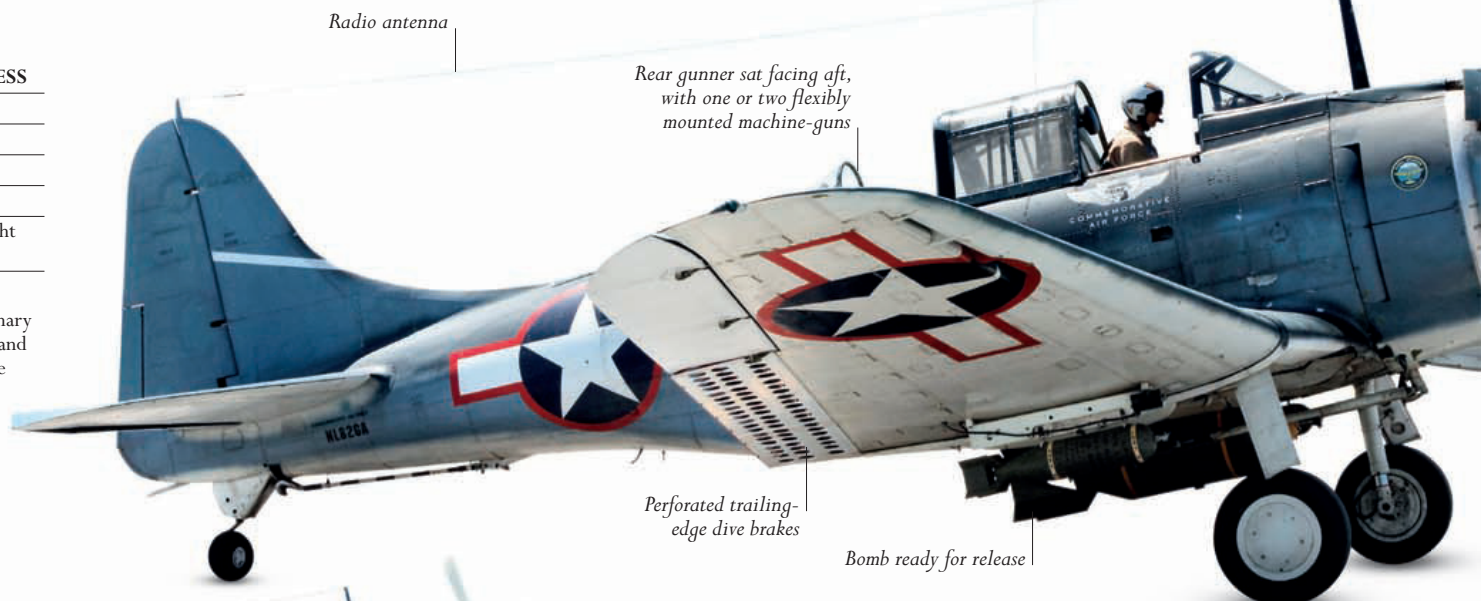
Date	1940	Origin	US
Wingspan	11.6m (38ft)		
Length	8.8m (28¾ft)		
Top speed	515kph (320mph)		
Engine	895kW (1,200hp) Pratt & Whitney R-1830-86 Twin Wasp radial		

When it came to developing a monoplane fighter, Grumman adapted the F3F biplane to create the F4F Wildcat, adding an improved tail and mid-mounted wing, and specifying a more powerful engine. Although capable, it was never a match for the Japanese Zero.

► DOUGLAS SBD DAUNTLESS

Date	1942	Origin	US
Wingspan	12.66m (41½ft)		
Length	10.09m (33ft)		
Top speed	410kph (255mph)		
Engine	895kW (1,200hp) Wright R-1820-60 Cyclone radial		

The "Slow But Deadly" (SBD) Dauntless was the US Navy's primary dive bomber until 1943. Rugged and dependable, it sank more Japanese ships than any other American aircraft, and later evolved into the A-1 Skyraider employed in Korea and Vietnam.



Radio antenna

Rear gunner sat facing aft, with one or two flexibly mounted machine-guns

Perforated trailing-edge dive brakes

Bomb ready for release



Large tail fin

◀ CURTISS SB2C HELLDIVER

Date	1943	Origin	US
Wingspan	15.17m (49¾ft)		
Length	11.81m (38¾ft)		
Top speed	475kph (295mph)		
Engine	1,416.8kW (1,900hp) Wright R-2600-20 Twin Cyclone radial		

Intended as a replacement for the Dauntless, the Helldiver suffered from a vast number of design flaws that had to be corrected before it could enter service. It had poor handling characteristics, but it ended the war with an admirable combat record.



Pilot's, wireless operator's, and gunner's positions all open to the elements

Wings could be folded back for storage

Torpedo carried below fuselage

▲ FAIREY SWORDFISH

Date	1936	Origin	UK
Wingspan	13.87m (45½ft)		
Length	10.87m (35¾ft)		
Top speed	225kph (140mph)		
Engine	514.5kW (690hp) Bristol Pegasus IIIM.3 radial		

Though considered obsolete even before the start of World War II, the "Stringbag" (so called because of wide variety of equipment it was cleared to carry) scored some notable successes, sinking an Italian battleship and damaging two more at Taranto in November 1940. Six months later a Swordfish disabled the German battleship *Bismarck*, allowing her to be sunk.

